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George E. Winkler:

Man of a Passing Race

By AB KENT
Times Staff

The man sat motionless for a moment on the hard-back chair, a large tweed cap square on his head, rumpled grey suit hung on a bony frame.

He resembled the ancient miner's duffel bag propped against the wall behind him.

With a dry chuckle he said: "I bucked the Consolidated Mining and Smelting for 40 years and beat them out. I don't know of much better success than that.

"As a rule, prospectors got the small end of the stick," he added wistfully.

Here was one prospector who had made it, not staggeringly rich, perhaps, but enough to endow university scholarships for budding geologists.

George E. Winkler, in his 89th year, has difficulty reaching his second-floor downtown office six days a week.

His legs are not what they used to be when back-packing grub, rock samples and prospector's pick over half the province of B.C. for 60 years. He figures he hiked 5,000 miles in his travels.

Eyes grow dim and hearing weak, but his recollections are perfect. Names, dates and places roll easily off his tongue, more articulately than many a young mod.

George Winkler also was a poet, revealing in verse the lonely solitude of mining camps from the Lardeau to Zeballos, the Alaska Panhandle to Similkameen.

Verse Published

His works rank with those of Klondyke poet Robert Service and share with him and W. H. Drummond the pages of a book long out of print — Rhymes of the Miner.

One of the 15 Winkler poems it contains is A Passing Race, with these lines:

We men of the pick are a passing race;
Wave on wave, growing less and less,
We come and we pass, leaving little trace
Of our intercourse with the wilderness . . .
What did we find if we found no treasure
To compensate for the losing of ease?
Only possessions ourselves can measure,
And muse of in secret with rocks and trees.

★ ★ ★

He regrets none of it.

"I don't know of any other life that would have been as interesting to me."

And now he feels he is "not badly off," though his clothes and dingy office seem to say the opposite.

Even though it was liquidated some eight years ago, the old mining company Winkler formed in 1915 is still proclaimed in gold letters on the office door at 1110 Government:

Gabbro Copper Mines Ltd. Registered Office.

The sign is stuck there with masking tape, a tangible link with the past and symbol of a prospector's victory.

He was president of Gabbro for 40 years and because he hung on — often paying the taxes out of his own pocket — he became the largest individual shareholder in the Sunro mine at Jordan River, the place where he beat CM and S, now called Cominco and part of the Canadian Pacific empire.

Winkler keeps going to the office as a ritual because the accumulated bits and pieces of a lifetime's prospecting and writing are there. That is where he reads with his huge glass magnifier and where he meets his friends for a chat.

Tell-Tale Signs

The old prospector put down the butt of a cigar he had been smoking, whose fumes permeate a threadbare carpet and sagging cot along one wall. He stretches there to put the drops in his watery eyes.

Yes, staking and hanging on to the Gabbro and Sunlock claims on Jordan River was his best success. Anyone who ever fought the CPR would agree.

Among the fading pictures on his walls is a large aerial photo showing clearly the Leech River fault through which he stumbled more than half a century ago in quest of copper.

The unbelievably rough terrain upland from the river mouth was where he staked his claims and where millions have since been made between the rise and fall of metal markets.

Winkler spent the winter of 1915-16 near the Forebay reservoir high above Jordan River.

"There was 16 feet of snow that winter and it dropped to two-below, so you can imagine what kind of a time I had."

It was only a plank cabin, not very warm, and "I had to dig my firewood from under the snow."

Racetrack Link

Cominco controls 84 per cent of the Jordan River mine, which has been worked by a succession of companies over the years, surviving shutdowns, crippling floods and washouts.

Winkler first became involved in 1909 while working in a camp commissary for Vancouver Island Power Co., which became B.C. Electric, then installing its Jordan River hydroelectric plant.

As an amateur geologist, he had seen interesting signs among the rocks at the river mouth and surmised they were carried downstream from an ore body somewhere back in the Sooke Range.

—John McKay photo

WINKLER . . . no more back-packing

Some gold was found on the flumeway from the hydro diversion dam and during the next few years Winkler took many samples including some that assayed encouragingly as silver and molybdenum.

"I kept it (the molybdenum) under my hat for 50 years," Winkler said, hoping the government would force the E and N (CPR) Railway to give up its base metal rights or make it pay taxes: "They may do yet."

Then Winkler found copper mineralization near the diversion dam and began staking claims.

A friend in Victoria had a little money to back the 40-year-old prospector. He was piledriving contractor Stuart Campbell, a man who liked to play the horses.

Winkler's original claims have a curious connection with the ponies. Campbell had once been lucky with a horse named Sunloch.

"So I called them Sunloch 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 and 6," Winkler said. The last one was staked July 30, 1915.

"I took the samples to Campbell and he asked me if it was any good. I said this came out of streak about 12 feet wide, but it would need an assay. I said I thought it would be 2½ per cent copper with a trace of gold and a trace of silver."

The assayist guessed 1 per cent copper with traces of gold and silver.

"I told him if I thought that, I wouldn't pay you $3 for an assay."

The analyst was astonished to find the sample went 3 per cent copper, or 60 pounds to the ton, with a trace of gold and from ¼ to a half-ounce of silver.

Campbell, with more of a mind for horses than prospecting, was still dubious. But by then the 15-day limit on recording claims was nearly up.

"It was Friday the 13th and I said, 'I don't suppose you want to record them today?' He said, 'I once won $13,000 on 13 tickets — you go and record them'."

Campbell took 25 per cent of the stock in Sunloch with Winkler taking the rest, which he divided with a few other backers, retaining better than 50 per cent for himself.

Meanwhile, by September of 1915 by working on the river, Winkler had staked his Gabbro claims on some 800 acres adjoining the Sunloch group, naming these after the typical iron-bearing ore.

Vein Untouched

Around that time the CPR subsidiary was trying to prove up enough copper ore on the coast to justify a smelter, Winker said. They already had interest in Anyox and Coast Copper and were getting control of Sunloch.

But they decided there was insufficient tonnage to make a refinery economic and dropped their options to explore Gabbro.

Noranda Explorations came on the scene. Winker offered Noranda an option to drill Gabbro on the basis of 10 cents a share for 600,000 treasury shares.

Winkler thinks CM and S felt confident no other company would touch the situation.

"They were waiting for me to drop out," he said.

When Noranda became curious CM and S wanted back in and Winkler wouldn't have them. Noranda accepted the option terms, took drills on to the property and struck a zone which to this day has not been exploited.

"I wouldn't like to say if it has commercial value," the prospector said. "I will say it has the highest cobalt values for that type," outside of Sudbury and Manitoba operations of Falconbridge and International Nickel.

"There's a lot of things about that camp they'll be investigating long after I'm gone," Winkler said.

He rose suddenly to fetch one of the rocks piled on a cupboard. Holding it out he said that sample assayed up to 7 per cent copper with nickel and cobalt values. It had come from a 3½-foot vein in one of the tunnels.

The old man reflected, "I've had $8,000 in dividends in spite of their shutdowns."

Finally, about 1950, Noranda and Cominco made a deal to amalgamate the properties and the Sunro company was formed — named for Sunloch and Gabbro. It was that or let the properties "lie idle for 20 years."

When Gabbro was closed up Winkler was given 20,000 shares of Sunro "in place of a pension."

He laughed his high-pitched glee, oblivious of the cigar ash scattered over the front of an old wool cardigan worn under his coat. He wanted to keep talking about Jordan River.

Best Success

"Something else bothers me," he said.

"Hydro (successor to B.C. Electric) went about 8,000 feet through Sunro. The Sunro report said there was 1,000 feet of continuous mineralization, the best a little over 1 per cent (copper) across 35 feet. But nothing else."

Winkler knows there is copper in that block through which Hydro drilled a new penstock. He showed a sample with free copper glinting like flecks of red gold.

According to the agreement with Sunro, the ore can't be mined within about 75 feet of the tunnel.

That may be richest part of all the claims, and it can't be touched.

It's good to be taking the home trail,
With packs and consciences light—
Even supposing we did fail
To conquer that distant height.

(From The Prospector, George E. Winkler)

ORIGINAL PORTAL to the Sunlock claims is shown here in 1919. Photo depicts a tramway long since toppled into the canyon. In the rugged terrain upland from Jordan River's mouth is where Winkler staked his claims and where millions of dollars have since been made between the rise and fall of metal markets.

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